moon, though it set up space stations like the Salyuts between 1973 and 1976, and Mir which was in orbit from 1986 to 2001. After enabling an array of satellites that boosted communication, navigation and many other applications, the US-Soviet Union space race ended with the fall of the Soviet Union in 1991.

The great nation's disintegration could not have happened at a worse time for our cryogenic plans. By 1989, the Eastern Bloc of nations had, one by one, overthrown their Communist governments and, by Gorbachev's own plan, the Soviet Union was getting increasingly democratized.

By April 1990, Soviet Union had started its race towards its end, having introduced a law allowing any republic to cede from the union if two-thirds of its population so felt. Russia had started charting its own course a year earlier, electing the Congress of People's Deputies of which Boris Yeltsin became the chairman on 12 June 1990.

Russia voted for the continuation of Soviet Union in a referendum in March 1990, but Yeltsin asserted that Russian laws superseded Soviet laws. By June 1991, Boris Yeltsin was elected the president of the Russian Federation.

Gorbachev was readying for the New Union Treaty when hardcore communists attempted the August Coup. When Gorbachev emerged from a few days of house arrest, Yeltsin had emerged powerful. Many republics declared independence and went their way.

When only Kazakhstan remained, Yeltsin took control of whatever was left of the Soviet Government. On the Christmas day of 1991, Gorbachev resigned and announced the formal. The next day, the Supreme Soviet officially announced that it and Soviet Union have ceased to exist.

Now Yeltsin was the sole political power centre in Russia, but the dissolution of Soviet Union had sent Russia, and all the other republics, into a financial tailspin. First we thought it was good for us, as the rupee appreciated tremendously against the ruble. But it turned out that a weakened Russia was struggling to withstand pressure from the US to cancel the cryogenic contract with India.